One God in Three Persons

Matthew 3:13–17 · Matthew 28:19 · John 1:1–18

The big idea: God is one, and the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are each fully God, equal in power and glory. He made the world out of fullness, not need, and he has made himself known in Jesus.

Before you meet: Read

Matthew 3:13–17 | John 1:1–18 | Acts 17:24–25

Open (5 minutes)

What is the hardest thing about God for you to understand? What would you most like to ask him?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Nor is he served by human hands, as though he _____ anything, since he himself gives to all mankind life and _____ and everything." *(Acts 17:25)*

Jesus told his followers to baptize "in the _____ of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit." *(Matthew 28:19)*

"No one has ever seen God; God the only Son, who is at the Father's side, he has made him _____." *(John 1:18)*

Discuss

1. God does not need anything from us. Why might that be good news and not cold news? *Acts 17:24–25*

2. In your own words, why is God not one person wearing three masks, and not three gods? How does the scene at the Jordan help? *Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 3:16–17*

3. Jesus said, "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father." What is one thing Jesus did in the Gospels that shows you what God is like? *John 1:18; 14:9*

Memory verse

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit."

Matthew 28:19

Pray

Pray to the Father, through the Son, by the help of the Spirit. Thank him that he has made himself known in Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 4

One God in Three Persons

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Matthew 3:13–17 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the three fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Genesis 1:1–2:3).

Main points to land

1. There is one God in three persons, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, the same in substance, equal in power and glory (Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 3:16–17; 28:19; WSC 6).
2. God made the world out of his own fullness, so we come to him with empty hands. Jesus is God making himself known (John 1:18; 14:9), and he will never cast out anyone who comes to him (John 6:37).
3. Christians pray to the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit (Ephesians 2:18), and live under the grace of all three (2 Corinthians 13:14).

Core doctrine to teach

The Trinity CORE DOCTRINE 2 OF 26

There is one God, and he exists eternally as three persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. They are not three gods, and they are not one God wearing three masks. Each person is fully God, equal in power and glory, and each is distinct from the others. *Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:19; John 1:1–3; 2 Corinthians 13:14*

Answer key (Observe)

1. needed; breath
2. name
3. known

Questions people will ask

How can God be three and one? Isn't that a contradiction?

It would be if God were one and three in the same sense. He is one in being and three in persons: one What, three Whos. Most comparisons (water, ice, and steam; an egg) end up teaching one of the two errors on the Shield. Say what Scripture says and then bow. A God we could fully figure out would be about our size.

Closing prayer

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, one God, we worship you. Thank you that you needed nothing and still made us, and that the Son has made you known. Keep us from making you small, and draw each of us to know you through Jesus. Amen.